PLACEHOLDER READING — replace with the real study material.

The History of Tea

Tea is one of the most popular drinks in the world. According to an old Chinese story, tea was discovered by Emperor Shen Nung almost five thousand years ago. One day, while the emperor was resting under a tree, a few leaves fell into his pot of boiling water. He tasted the water and found it fresh and pleasant. This, the story says, was the first cup of tea.

For many centuries, tea was known only in China. People drank it as a medicine at first, and only later as an everyday drink. Traders slowly carried tea along the Silk Road to other parts of Asia. By the ninth century, tea had reached Japan, where it became an important part of the culture. The Japanese tea ceremony, which developed over hundreds of years, turned the simple act of making tea into a form of art.

Tea arrived in Europe in the early seventeenth century, brought by Dutch and Portuguese ships. At first it was very expensive, and only rich families could afford it. In England, tea became fashionable after 1662, when a Portuguese princess who loved tea married the English king. Within a hundred years, tea had become the national drink of Britain.

Today, tea is grown in more than sixty countries, from the mountains of India and Sri Lanka to the hills of Kenya. Billions of cups are drunk every day. Although coffee is more popular in some countries, tea remains the second most consumed drink in the world after water.

Scientists have studied tea for many years. Some research suggests that tea may be good for the heart and may help people relax while staying alert. Green tea, black tea, and white tea all come from the same plant; the difference lies in how the leaves are treated after picking.

From an accidental discovery under a tree to a global industry, the story of tea shows how a simple plant can change daily life across the whole world.